

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

Marigold Grow Guide

For Marigold Seedlings, Home Gardens, Small Farms, Borders, Containers, and Companion Planting

Guide Includes	Quick rescue chart • growth numbers • sunlight/soil/water • feeding • harvesting • leaf problems • flowering • farmer/home notes • sanitation • hardening off • transplanting • pests • diseases
Main plant types	French marigold (<i>Tagetes patula</i>), African/American marigold (<i>Tagetes erecta</i>), signet marigold (<i>Tagetes tenuifolia</i>), and common garden marigolds
Support	WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

Customer note: marigolds are useful, beautiful garden plants, but they are not magic pest-control shields. They can support a healthier garden, attract beneficial insects, and some French marigolds are useful in nematode management when grown properly as a cover crop, but customers should still monitor plants and act early.

Quick Rescue: If You See This, Do This

What You See	Most Likely Cause	What To Do First
Seedling wilts after planting	Transplant shock, hot sun, dry root ball	Shade 1-2 days, water soil gently, transplant evening/early morning
Tall leafy plant, few flowers	Too much shade or too much nitrogen	Move to 6+ hours sun; reduce high-nitrogen feeding
Flowers turning brown/gray mold	Botrytis/gray mold in wet conditions	Remove bad flowers, avoid overhead watering, improve airflow
Leaves stippled, dusty, webbing	Spider mites	Spray undersides, reduce drought stress, repeat every 3-5 days
Leaves curled, sticky, small insects	Aphids, whiteflies, or thrips	Check undersides, spray mild soap solution, repeat every 3-5 days
Ragged holes/slime trails	Slugs/snails or caterpillars	Check evening/morning, remove pests, reduce hiding spots
Plant base browns and collapses	Stem/crown/root rot from wet soil	Improve drainage; remove badly diseased plants
Lower leaves with bronze/purple/yellow issues	Nutrient/pH stress or water stress	Check watering, drainage, and light feeding
Deformed flowers, strange green growth	Aster yellows or viral-like disease	Remove infected plants; control leafhoppers and weeds

Quick Numbers Page

Item	Specific Guide Range
Plant type	Warm-season annual flower
Main botanical group	Tagetes spp.
Seed germination	About 5-14 days; often around 7 days at 70-75°F / 21-24°C
Transplant age	About 4-6 weeks from sowing, when sturdy with several true leaves
Hardening off	5-7 days before full outdoor exposure
Sunlight	6+ hours direct sun daily
Watering	Moderate/regular water; let top 1 inch of soil begin to dry
French marigold height	6-18 inches
African/American marigold height	10-36 inches; some types 1-3 ft
Signet marigold height	Usually under 12 inches to about 18 inches
Small border spacing	6-9 inches for compact French types
General mass planting spacing	10-14 inches
African/tall spacing	12-18 inches
Bloom timing from transplant	Usually 3-6 weeks after transplant if healthy and in sun
Bloom timing from seed	Usually 45-60 days for many garden types; some large African types may take 60-90 days
Deadheading frequency	Every 5-10 days for tidy plants and more blooms
Container depth	At least 8-10 inches for compact types; 10-12+ inches for larger types

Numbers vary by variety. French marigolds are usually shorter and bushier; African/American marigolds usually grow taller with larger blooms.

Marigold Types: Identification and Differences

Type	How To Identify It	Best Use / Difference
French marigold (Tagetes patula)	Compact, bushy plants; often 6-18 inches tall; flowers usually up to about 2 inches, often yellow, orange, maroon, or bicolor.	Good for borders, containers, vegetable-garden edges, and small home gardens. Often the type discussed for nematode-support cover cropping.
African/American marigold (Tagetes erecta)	Taller upright plants; often 10-36 inches; large double flowers can reach about 4-5 inches on some types.	Good for strong color, cut flowers, and bigger beds. Needs good airflow; large blooms can rot in wet weather.
Signet marigold (Tagetes tenuifolia)	Fine, delicate foliage; smaller single flowers, often under 1 inch; many plants stay under 12 inches.	Good for edging, pots, and edible-looking ornamental plantings; often lighter, finer texture.
Hybrid marigolds	May combine compact habit with larger flowers and longer bloom performance.	Good for landscaping and sales when customers want tidy, showy plants.
Pot marigold / calendula (Calendula officinalis)	Not a true Tagetes marigold; daisy-like flowers and different care pattern.	Do not mix in this guide unless you are selling calendula specifically.

Sunlight, Soil, and Water

Marigolds are best sold as easy, bright, sun-loving plants. The main rule is simple: give strong sun, good drainage, and do not keep the roots soggy.

Need	Specific Target
Sunlight	At least 6 hours direct sun daily; 8 hours is even better for heavy blooming
Shade warning	Too much shade causes leafy plants and fewer flowers
Soil	Loose, fertile, well-draining soil; tolerates sand, loam, and clay if drainage is good
Water	Moderate and regular; water the soil, not the flowers
Wet-weather warning	Avoid overhead watering on tall plants because wet blooms and heavy stems can break or rot
Mulch	Thin mulch layer can reduce soil splash; keep mulch slightly away from stem
Drainage	Never allow trays, pots, or beds to stay waterlogged

For Jamaica and hot conditions: give morning and midday sun where possible, but keep new seedlings watered while roots establish. Once established, marigolds tolerate short dry periods better than many tender herbs.

Feeding Guide

Stage	Timing	Feeding Direction
At planting	Day 0	Mix compost into soil. Use light balanced fertilizer only if soil is poor.
After establishment	7-14 days after transplant	Feed lightly if leaves are pale or growth is slow.
Blooming stage	When buds/flowers form	Avoid heavy nitrogen; it can push leaves instead of flowers.
Container plants	Every 3-4 weeks if needed	Use a mild balanced feed; water first if soil is dry.
Flower beds/small farm rows	Every 4-6 weeks if growth slows	Light compost or mild complete fertilizer; do not overfeed.

Strong point for customers: too much nitrogen or too much shade can make marigolds leafy with few flowers. Feed for steady growth, not excessive leaf growth.

Harvesting and Flower Care

Marigolds can be sold as ornamental plants, companion plants, border plants, and cut flowers depending on the variety.

Goal	When / How
Keep plant blooming	Remove spent flowers every 5-10 days. This is called deadheading.
Cut flowers	Harvest when blooms are partly open to mostly open, depending on use. Cut early morning.
Dried flowers / seed saving	Allow selected flowers to dry on the plant, then collect when fully dry.
Market/display pots	Remove brown blooms and yellow leaves before delivery or sale.
Garden color	Plant in groups of 3, 5, 7, or long borders for stronger visual effect.

For large African marigolds, remove old wet blooms quickly during rainy weather to reduce gray mold and flower rot.

Leaf Color and Plant Problem Guide

Leaf / Plant Look	Possible Cause	What To Do
Medium to deep green leaves, steady buds	Healthy growth	Continue sun, drainage, and light feeding.
Pale green or yellow leaves	Low nitrogen, poor roots, overwatering, or low light	Check drainage and sunlight; feed lightly if soil is poor.
Bronze speckling on lower leaves	Possible pH/nutrient disorder in soilless media	Avoid overfeeding; flush pots if salts build up; use balanced media.
Purple lower leaves	Possible phosphorus stress, cool/root stress, or nutrient imbalance	Improve root health and steady feeding; avoid cold/wet soil.
Leaves lose green color with webbing	Spider mites, especially hot weather	Spray undersides; repeat every 3-5 days; avoid drought stress.
Leaf margins cup/roll inward	Leafhopper injury or pest stress	Check for pests; remove badly damaged growth.
Plant wilts at base	Stem rot, root rot, or wilt disease	Improve drainage; remove severely infected plants.

Flowering, Deadheading, and Seed Heads

Situation	Likely Reason	Action
Lots of leaves but few flowers	Too much shade or nitrogen	Increase sun to 6+ hours; reduce nitrogen.
Flowers small or slow	Plant still young, poor sun, low fertility	Give time, light feeding, and stronger sun.
Flowers brown/soft after rain	Wet blooms, gray mold, poor airflow	Remove bad flowers; water soil only.
Tall plants falling over	Large African types, wind, heavy rain	Stake if needed; space 12-18 inches.
Spent flowers left on plant	Energy goes into seed heads	Deadhead every 5-10 days for tidy plants.
Want seed for later	Let selected flowers dry fully	Save only from healthy plants; store dry.

For sales: teach customers that deadheading is not complicated - just pinch or cut off old brown flowers. This keeps the plant looking clean and encourages more bloom.

Small Farmer Notes

- Use marigolds as borders, row markers, pollinator-attraction strips, and ornamental companion plants around vegetables.
- Do not promise that marigolds will repel every pest. Customers must still inspect crops for whiteflies, aphids, mites, worms, and disease.
- For nematode support, French marigolds are the type most often discussed. Best effect comes when grown as a dense cover crop for about 2 months before planting susceptible crops, then incorporated or removed according to the system.
- For display beds, group compact French marigolds 6-10 inches apart and larger types 12-18 inches apart.
- Use staggered planting every 3-4 weeks if selling flowering marigolds over a longer season.
- Keep nursery trays weed-free and remove diseased plants quickly so problems do not spread.

Important wording for customers: marigold is a garden support plant, not a replacement for good farming practice.

Home Garden Notes

- For customers buying 2-6 plants, recommend compact French or signet marigolds for pots and vegetable-bed edges.
- Plant near tomatoes, peppers, herbs, lettuce, cabbage, and fruiting vegetables as a color and companion border.
- Use pots at least 8-10 inches deep for compact types; larger types do better in 10-12+ inch containers.
- Place where plants receive at least 6 hours of sun.
- Water the soil when the top 1 inch begins to dry; avoid soaking flowers repeatedly.
- Remove old flowers weekly to keep plants attractive.
- In rainy periods, give more spacing and airflow to prevent rotting flowers and stem disease.

Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

Marigolds are usually tough plants, but clean handling protects nursery trays and customer seedlings.

- Wash hands before handling seedling trays, especially after touching diseased plants, soil, cigarettes, compost piles, or chemical sprays.
- Do not rest cigarettes, food, dirty tools, or used plant labels on seedling trays.
- Use clean scissors or pruners when cutting flowers or removing diseased growth.
- Remove plants with severe wilting, rot at soil line, aster yellows symptoms, or heavy pest infestation from healthy stock.
- Avoid splashing soil onto leaves; many leaf diseases spread faster with wet, dirty foliage.
- Clean reusable trays and pots before planting new seedlings.

Hardening Off Seedlings

Hardening off prepares tray or small-pot seedlings for direct sun, wind, and outdoor heat. This section is near the back because not every customer is transplanting from trays, but it is very important for customers who are.

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade or gentle morning sun for 2-3 hours
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 3-4 hours; protect from harsh afternoon heat
Day 5-6	Longer outdoor exposure; keep tray moist, not soggy
Day 7	Ready to transplant in early morning or late evening

If seedlings wilt badly during hardening off, move them back to shade, water gently, and continue more slowly.

Transplanting From Trays or Small Pots

Step	Instruction
1	Water seedlings 1-2 hours before transplanting.
2	Prepare the bed or pot first so roots are not exposed too long.
3	Transplant early morning before 9:00 a.m. or late evening after 4:30 p.m.
4	Keep the root ball together as much as possible.
5	Plant at the same depth as the pot/tray, or only slightly deeper if leggy.
6	Press soil gently around roots; do not compact hard.
7	Water immediately at soil level.
8	Give light shade for 1-2 days if the sun is very harsh.
9	Check daily for the first 3-5 days.

Spacing reminder: compact French types can be planted 6-10 inches apart; general mass planting 10-14 inches; taller African/American types 12-18 inches apart.

Common Pests

Pest	Signs	First Action
Spider mites	Leaves lose green color, dusty look, fine webbing; worse in hot weather	Spray leaf undersides, reduce drought stress, repeat every 3-5 days
Aphids	Small soft insects, sticky leaves, curled new growth	Spray off with water or mild soap solution; control ants
Thrips	Silvery/bronze marks, distorted flowers or leaves	Remove badly damaged flowers, use sticky traps, spray early
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects fly up; yellowing/sticky leaves	Spray undersides and use yellow sticky traps
Caterpillars / leaf tiers	Chewed leaves, leaves or flower buds webbed together	Handpick; remove damaged growth
Slugs/snails	Ragged holes and slime trails	Check evening/morning; remove hiding places; use safe bait if needed
Leafminers	Winding pale tunnels inside leaves	Remove affected leaves; manage weeds

Most marigold pest problems are not fatal if caught early. The biggest mistakes are ignoring mites in hot weather and keeping plants too wet.

Common Diseases and Disorders

Disease / Disorder	Signs	What To Do
Botrytis / gray mold	Flowers turn brown and decay; gray mold on fading flowers	Pick off and destroy infected flowers; reduce wetness
Leaf spot	Oval or irregular gray/black spots, often lower leaves first	Remove affected leaves; improve airflow; avoid overhead watering
Stem/crown/root rot	Base turns brown/shriveled; plant wilts and dies	Improve drainage; remove infected plants
Aster yellows	Deformed flowers, strange growth, yellowing/stunting	Remove infected plants; manage leafhopper vectors and weeds
Wilt disease	Plant wilts and dies even with moisture	Remove infected plants; avoid reusing contaminated soil
Nutrient disorder	Yellowing, bronzing, purple lower leaves	Correct drainage/fertilizer balance; use mild complete fertilizer

Rainy-weather reminder: large African marigold blooms can hold water and rot. Smaller-flowered types often handle wet periods more neatly.

ParaLife Trees Support

Need help with your marigold plant?

Send clear photos by WhatsApp:

- The full plant
- The damaged leaves or flowers
- The underside of leaves
- The soil, pot, or bed
- Any insects, webbing, slime trails, spots, or rotten areas

WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

Sources used for grow-guide guidance

Iowa State University Extension - Growing Marigolds in the Home Garden; UF/IFAS - Tagetes erecta Marigold; UC Statewide IPM Program - Marigold pest/disorder guidance. General customer recommendations were adapted for ParaLife Trees seedlings, Jamaican heat, home gardens, containers, and small-farm use.

ParaLife Trees - Planting a Life in Paradise